

to India's impoverished masses, but improved coaching stock and other amenities together with properly coordinated road services should better the conditions of travel in the future. The railways should soon be able to meet the demand for goods traffic and will expand to meet further industrial and agricultural production." He was of the firm belief that when it came to the railways, "India has a great asset which must be carefully nursed and firmly administered."

Into the storm

The railways also investigated new lines of construction and the restoration of derailed lines. Passenger train mileage, though less than pre-war days, had shown an increase, with the railways resuming more than a thousand train services. Locomotives had been ordered, even as the construction of new locomotives was underway, and the stock of goods wagons was increased to improve service.

With a vast nationalized network, the financial stability of the railways was central to the economy of the country. The political upheaval in the follow-up to the carving of two sovereign states from a cultural and historical whole, however, created adverse conditions for its smooth functioning. Labour discontent, increased lawlessness on the rail network, inflation, and curfews threatened to derail the arduous process of returning to pre-war conditions. On 15 August 1947, India became independent and Pakistan was born. Everything was divided. The land, its people, ships, typewriters, food stock, and the railway lines. Even as the two Governments tried to come to terms with the new borders, the railways reeled from the division. A unified and cohesive system, it was never meant to be partitioned.